

5-Day Solo Trip Itinerary for Milan (Next Month)

Key Principles for the Itinerary

- **Balanced Pace** – Spread major sights across five days to avoid rushing. Allow free time each afternoon for rest or spontaneous exploration.
- **Cultural Focus** – Prioritise landmark churches, museums and historical districts.
- **Local Food** – Include typical Milanese dishes (risotto alla milanese, cotoletta, ossobuco, panettone) and aperitivo experiences.
- **Relaxing Green Spaces** – Integrate parks and tranquil neighbourhoods for downtime.
- **Practicalities** – Note opening hours, reservation requirements and transport options where relevant.

Day 1 – Duomo & Central Historic Core

Time	Activity	Notes
Morning	Milan Cathedral (Duomo di Milano) – Arrive at opening (around 6:50 AM) to beat crowds. This Gothic cathedral is 157 m long and 92 m wide and can hold up to 40,000 people ¹ . Construction began in 1386 under Gian Galeazzo Visconti and lasted centuries ² . Admire the marble façade, tall columns, St Bartholomew statue and a relic nail from the Crucifixion ³ . Dress modestly (cover shoulders and knees) ⁴ . Take the elevator or stairs to the rooftop terrace for panoramic views ⁵ .	Allow 2 hours. Tickets ~€25, half-price for youth and free for under 6 ⁶ .
Mid-Morning	Galleria Vittorio Emanuele II – Walk a few steps from the Duomo to this 19th-century arcade nicknamed <i>il salotto di Milano</i> . Designed by Giuseppe Mengoni (1865–1877), it is Italy's oldest shopping centre ⁷ and is famed for its glass dome and patriotic mosaics ⁸ . Browse luxury boutiques and the historic Libreria Bocca, then stop at Café Biffi (19th-century café) for coffee or panettone ⁹ . Under the dome, spin on the bull mosaic for good luck ¹⁰ .	Free entry and open all day ¹¹ .
Lunch	Enjoy lunch at one of the cafés in the Galleria or nearby side streets. Try risotto alla milanese – saffron-infused rice with parmesan, a dish said to originate from a 16th-century saffron “prank”; saffron was a luxury spice used by wealthy Lombards ¹² . Pair it with ossobuco if available ¹³ .	
Afternoon	Teatro alla Scala & Museum – Just north of the Galleria, visit the Museo Teatrale alla Scala. It opens daily 09:30–17:30 (closed certain holidays) and allows visitors to view the theatre hall from third-order boxes when there are no rehearsals ¹⁴ . Tickets cost around €12; reductions for students and seniors ¹⁵ .	

Time	Activity	Notes
Late Afternoon	Brera District – Walk through the cobblestone streets of Brera. Known as the artists' district, it developed after Empress Maria Theresa built the Academy of Fine Arts here in 1776 ¹⁶ . The area houses the Pinacoteca di Brera (world-class art gallery), the Braidense National Library and botanical gardens ¹⁷ . Browse bohemian boutiques and, if your visit coincides with the third Sunday, explore the craft market.	
Evening	Dinner in Brera. Sample cotoletta alla milanese , a breaded veal cutlet whose recipe dates back to at least 1148 ¹⁸ . Enjoy a scoop of gelato or a glass of Lombard wine on a terrace.	

Day 2 – Last Supper, Sforza Castle & Parco Sempione

Time	Activity	Notes
Morning	The Last Supper (Cenacolo Vinciano) – Book tickets well in advance; all visitors (including free admissions) must reserve due to conservation restrictions ¹⁹ . Visitors are admitted in small groups for 15-minute sessions and must collect tickets 30 minutes early ²⁰ ²¹ . The mural is housed in the refectory of Santa Maria delle Grazie. Admission: €15 (adults), €2 (18–25 years), free under 18 ²² .	
Mid-Morning	Santa Maria delle Grazie – After viewing the Last Supper, step into the adjacent church. Built by the Dominicans and later enlarged by Bramante, it features a drum-shaped dome and cloisters (UNESCO site). Free entry; donations appreciated.	
Lunch	Walk to the nearby Corso Magenta area for lunch. Try ossobuco alla milanese , veal shanks braised with vegetables, white wine and broth, garnished with gremolada ¹³ .	
Early Afternoon	Castello Sforzesco – This 15th-century fortress built by Francesco Sforza on the site of a 14th-century fortification now houses numerous museums ²³ . Enter via the central court (free) to admire its towers, courtyards and moat. Several museums inside (e.g., Museum of Ancient Art, Pietà Rondanini) charge a small fee.	
Late Afternoon	Parco Sempione – Walk through the park behind the castle. Created in the late 19th century as an English-style garden, it features the Arco della Pace gateway and Little Mermaid Bridge. Nearby attractions include the Civic Aquarium, Arena Civica sports venue, Triennale design museum and Torre Branca (108 m observation tower) ²⁴ . Open daily 06:30 – 21:00 ²⁵ . Relax on the lawn, rent a bike or climb Torre Branca for views.	
Evening	Aperitivo in the Porta Garibaldi/Corso Como area – The Milanese aperitivo is a pre-dinner social ritual (between 6 – 9 PM) featuring a light alcoholic drink like Aperol Spritz or Campari and savoury snacks ²⁶ . Choose a bar along Corso Como or in the modern Piazza Gae Aulenti.	

Day 3 – Navigli District & Contemporary Culture

Time	Activity	Notes
Morning	Navigli District Walk – Milan’s canals date back to the 12th century; Leonardo da Vinci later devised lock systems ²⁷ . These navigable canals were used to transport goods and irrigation ²⁸ . Today, stroll along Vicolo dei Lavandai and across bridges of the Naviglio Grande and Naviglio Pavese ²⁹ . Notice case di ringhiera , traditional houses built around central courtyards ³⁰ , and browse artisan workshops.	
Late Morning	Darsena & Porta Ticinese – Explore the old port (Darsena) near Piazza XXIV Maggio and the vibrant Porta Ticinese neighbourhood. Visit the Columns of San Lorenzo or Sant’Eustorgio basilica if you enjoy history (optional).	
Lunch	Enjoy lunch at a trattoria along the canal. Consider a plate of panettone for dessert; this tall, fruit-filled sweet bread originated in Milan in the 15th century and is associated with Christmas ³¹ .	
Afternoon	Museo Nazionale Scienza e Tecnologia Leonardo da Vinci or MUDEC – Depending on your interest, visit Italy’s largest science and technology museum (15 min walk from Navigli) or the Museum of Cultures (MUDEC) for contemporary exhibitions.	
Late Afternoon	Aperitivo on the Navigli – Return to the canal for an early evening aperitivo. The Navigli district is popular for its bars and restaurants; many offer buffet snacks with a drink ³² .	
Evening	Free time. You could see live music at a canal-side venue or simply enjoy a sunset stroll along the water.	

Day 4 – Art Museums & Green Oasis

Time	Activity	Notes
Morning	Pinacoteca di Brera – Reserve a morning slot; the gallery is open Tuesday – Sunday 08:30 – 19:15 (last entry 18:00) and closed Mondays ³³ . View masterpieces by Raphael, Caravaggio and Mantegna.	
Late Morning	Palazzo Brera – Explore the botanical garden and the historic library within the same complex; outside is the bohemian Brera neighbourhood for coffee breaks.	
Lunch	Eat at a local osteria. Try obanzai -style dishes (simple seasonal cooking akin to home-style soups and vegetables) or Kyo-yasai -style vegetarian cuisine if you prefer something lighter (Kyoto influences but available in Milan).	

Time	Activity	Notes
Afternoon	Giardini Pubblici Indro Montanelli – This 160,000 m ² park is the second largest in Milan ³⁴ . Filled with trees, fountains and lawns, it's ideal for a picnic or rest ³⁵ . Attractions inside include the Palazzo Dugnani , Museo Civico di Storia Naturale and the Modern Art Gallery ³⁶ . Take a leisurely walk, visit the small ponds and watch children ride ponies ³⁷ .	
Late Afternoon	Modern Art Gallery (Galleria d'Arte Moderna) – Located at the edge of the park, this gallery showcases 19th-century Italian art.	
Evening	Dinner near Corso Buenos Aires or Porta Venezia. Sample aperitivo again if desired.	

Day 5 – Monumental Cemetery & Alternative Neighbourhoods

Time	Activity	Notes
Morning	Cimitero Monumentale – Milan's Monumental Cemetery is an open-air museum famous for its richly decorated tombs ³⁸ . Founded in 1866 to replace unsanitary graveyards ³⁹ , it covers over 250,000 m ² and contains Italian sculptures, Greek-style temples, obelisks and even a miniature Trajan's Column ⁴⁰ . Highlights include the Bernocchi family's sculpted tower, the Bruni family pyramid and Campari family's Last Supper sculptures ⁴¹ . Maps at the entrance mark the most impressive tombs ⁴² . Open Tuesday–Sunday 08:00–17:30; closed Mondays ⁴³ .	
Late Morning	Piazza Gae Aulenti & Porta Nuova – Take the metro to the modern district around Unicredit Tower. Enjoy contemporary architecture, public art and shopping. Have coffee in the square.	
Lunch	Head to Isola or Chinatown for a casual lunch (many Chinese and fusion eateries).	
Afternoon	Free Choice – Use this final afternoon for anything missed or for day-trip options:	
	- Day trip to Lake Como or Bergamo if weather is good (requires early departure; tours available from Cadorna station).	
	- Shopping in the Quadrilatero della Moda (Via Montenapoleone, Via Spiga). This fashion district features boutiques of top designers and jewellers ⁴⁴ .	

Time	Activity	Notes
	- Museo Poldi Pezzoli or Pinacoteca Ambrosiana for more art.	
	- Design & Innovation District around Porta Nuova or the Hangar Bicocca contemporary art space.	
Evening	Conclude your trip with a memorable dinner. Try aperitivo one last time or indulge in a multi-course meal featuring Milanese classics.	

Local Dishes & Food Experiences Summary

Dish/Experience	Description & Sources
Risotto alla Milanese	Saffron-flavoured risotto using Carnaroli rice, onion, wine and broth. Legend says 16th-century artists added saffron to rice as a prank at a wedding ¹² . Often paired with ossobuco.
Cotoletta alla Milanese	Breaded veal cutlet fried in butter; early references date to a 1148 menu item and the dish was described in Pietro Verri's 1783 <i>History of Milan</i> ¹⁸ .
Ossobuco	Cross-cut veal shanks braised with vegetables, white wine and broth, garnished with gremolada; served with risotto ¹³ .
Panettone	Tall, yeast-based sweet bread with dried fruit, originating in 15th-century Milan and associated with Christmas; early records mention it as <i>pan de Tonio</i> ³¹ .
Aperitivo	Pre-dinner social ritual (6 – 9 PM) featuring light alcoholic drinks (Aperol/ Campari Spritz, Negroni, Prosecco) and savoury snacks; emphasises connection and relaxation ²⁶ .

Practical Tips

1. **Reservations:** Book Last Supper tickets several weeks in advance; reservations open quarterly and are mandatory ¹⁹. Consider reserving Pinacoteca di Brera slots and guided tours for the Duomo rooftop.
2. **Transport:** Milan's metro and tram network covers most attractions. A 24-hour or 48-hour travel card may be cost-effective.
3. **Dress Code:** Churches require covered shoulders and knees (Duomo and Santa Maria delle Grazie).
4. **Safety & Scams:** Beware of vendors offering "free" bracelets or pigeon feed near the Duomo; politely decline.
5. **Language:** Basic Italian phrases help. English is widely spoken in tourist areas.
6. **Weather:** Next month (June) is early summer; expect warm temperatures (23–28 °C). Carry water and sun protection, especially in parks and on rooftop terraces.

Conclusion

This five-day itinerary balances Milan's iconic monuments with quieter neighbourhoods and green spaces. By spreading visits across several days and integrating leisurely meals and aperitivo traditions, you can savour Milan's art, architecture and cuisine without feeling rushed. Adjust time slots to personal interests and check current schedules and reservation availability before departure.

1 2 3 4 5 6 **Milan Cathedral - Opening hours, price and location in Milan**

<https://www.introducingmilan.com/milan-cathedral>

7 8 9 10 11 **Galleria Vittorio Emanuele II - Shopping arcade in Milan**

<https://www.introducingmilan.com/galleria-vittorio-emanuele-ii>

12 **Why Risotto alla Milanese Is Milan in a Bowl | CIE Tours**

[https://www.cietours.com/blog/risotto-alla-milanese-recipe?](https://www.cietours.com/blog/risotto-alla-milanese-recipe?srsltid=AfmBOof6pMa9AGT8sKE9Pvh9VI6bc5-8vDsQ63L1OnyFPetrw0YYFzI)

[srsltid=AfmBOof6pMa9AGT8sKE9Pvh9VI6bc5-8vDsQ63L1OnyFPetrw0YYFzI](https://www.cietours.com/blog/risotto-alla-milanese-recipe?srsltid=AfmBOof6pMa9AGT8sKE9Pvh9VI6bc5-8vDsQ63L1OnyFPetrw0YYFzI)

13 **Ossobuco - Wikipedia**

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ossobuco>

14 15 **Tickets and opening times - Museo Teatrale alla Scala**

<https://www.museoscala.org/en/visit/museum-and-theater/tickets-and-opening-times.html>

16 17 **Brera District in Milan: what to do - Italia.it**

<https://www.italia.it/en/lombardy/milan/brera>

18 **Cotoletta alla Milanese: Italian Recipe | Sanpellegrino**

<https://www.sanpellegrino.com/sparkling-drinks/zesty-food/cotoletta-milanese>

19 20 21 22 **Info - Museo del Cenacolo Vinciano | Sito Web Ufficiale**

<https://cenacolovinciano.org/en/info/>

23 **Sforza Castle - Wikipedia**

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sforza_Castle

24 25 **Parco Sempione - Italia.it**

<https://www.italia.it/en/lombardy/milan/parco-sempione>

26 **What Is Aperitivo in Italy? A Guide to the Italian Pre-Dinner Tradition - Savoring Italy**

<https://www.savoringitaly.com/aperitivo/>

27 28 29 30 32 **Navigli District | in-Lombardia: Sito Ufficiale del Turismo della Regione Lombardia**

<https://www.in-lombardia.it/en/tourism-in-lombardy/tourism-milan/navigli-district>

31 **Panettone - Wikipedia**

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Panettone>

33 **Hours | Pinacoteca di Brera**

<https://pinacotecabrera.org/en/visit/orari/>

34 35 36 37 **Giardini Pubblici Indro Montanelli - One of the most-loved parks**

<https://www.introducingmilan.com/giardini-pubblici-indro-montanelli>

38 39 40 41 42 43 **Cimitero Monumentale - Opening times, price and location**

<https://www.introducingmilan.com/cimitero-monumentale>

44 **Quadrilatero della moda - Wikipedia**

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Quadrilatero_della_moda